

The effect of the Vietnam War was felt for many years afterward, but Vietnam is now a peaceful and prosperous nation.

CASUALTIES OF WAR

One million Vietnamese troops on both sides **lost their lives** in the war, along with **4 million** Vietnamese civilians and **58,000** US troops. More than 153,000 US troops were seriously wounded; **the total number of Vietnamese casualties is unknown.**

UNIFICATION

The Paris Peace Accord held until renewed fighting broke out in January 1975. A final **communist offensive captured Saigon** on April 30 and reunified the country in 1976 as the Socialist Republic of Vietnam. Thousands who feared for their lives under the new government fled Vietnam in boats, many drowning before they could reach safety in neighboring countries. More than **1 million refugees** from the conflict eventually **settled in the US.**

VETERANS

More than 660 US servicemen were taken prisoner during the war; 591 of these were repatriated under the peace accord. However, **2,400 men are still missing in action.** Veterans' associations in the US are a vocal force in modern US politics.

MODERN VIETNAM

In 1986 the Vietnamese government relaxed its previous hard-line communist economic policies in favor of a more liberal policy of *doi moi* ("renovation") and **began to welcome foreign investment.** In 1995 Vietnam joined the Southeast Asian economic group ASEAN. War damage was immense due to heavy US bombing and the country continues to rely on overseas aid for reconstruction.

further alienated the US-backed South Vietnamese government from the people.

US withdrawal

The Vietnam War was opposed by increasing numbers of Americans who did not see why their troops were fighting a war with no just cause. The first major antiwar demonstrations took place in 1965, and grew in strength as more and more young men were drafted, or forced into military service. Television brought the reality

of the war into American homes on a daily basis. The last five years of the war were bloody and painful for both sides. The US started peace talks in Paris in August 1969 in order to find an orderly way out of the conflict. The talks continued until a peace accord was signed on January 27, 1973. US troops left South Vietnam to the Vietnamese 60 days later.



Viet Cong

Viet Cong fighters lacked the sophisticated weaponry and equipment of the US military, but they had the advantage of local knowledge and support.



Protests at home

US protests against the war were supported not just by traditional pacifists but also by a much larger constituency of peace campaigners, including civil rights campaigner Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. The war divided US society as no event had done that century.

“We are **determined to fight** for **independence**, national unity, democracy and **peace.**”

HO CHI MINH, NORTH VIETNAMESE LEADER, MAY 8, 1954

US troop deployment

The first US marines arrived in South Vietnam in March 1965. By July that year, more than 50,000 were in the country, as well as increasing numbers of US airmen and sailors. Numbers escalated to a peak of 543,500 troops in April 1969. In addition, 320,000 South Koreans, 47,000 Australians, and contingents from the Philippines, Thailand, and New Zealand fought alongside American troops. The Viet Cong and North Vietnamese troops received military aid and financial support from communist China and USSR, although no ground troops were committed. However, they did have the advantage of fighting on home soil, often with the active support of the local people.

The American plan in Vietnam was to attack North Vietnam from the air to stop it from aiding the Viet Cong. Operation “Rolling Thunder” targeted bridges, roads, railroads, airfields,

factories, fuel depots, and military installations, but failed to achieve its objectives. North Vietnam had a formidable air defense system, and kept supplies flowing to the south along the Ho Chi Minh Trail, a 12,500-mile (20,000-km) network of tracks and paved roads through the jungles of North Vietnam and neighboring Laos and Cambodia. The trail was well defended by anti-aircraft batteries and hidden from observation by the jungle through which it passed. By 1970, 18,000 tons of supplies flowed down the trail each month.

The US tried to deny the Viet Cong jungle cover by spraying Agent Orange, a chemical deployed to defoliate the jungle. It also used napalm, an incendiary liquid that burned everything it touched. Such tactics deprived local farmers of their crops and therefore their livelihood and



Hand-made Viet Cong machine gun

The USSR and China supplied North Vietnam with most of its weapons, but its fighters also made their own arms—such as this machine gun—as well as using weaponry captured from the US.

Wounded in action

The sight of young American troops wounded in action appeared on US television news night after night and did as much to turn American opinion against the war as any political debate.

Civilian casualties

Many Vietnamese civilians were caught up in the war: US bombing raids targeting Viet Cong only served to alienate those it claimed to support.

oil refineries and authorized Kennedy's successor, Lyndon B. Johnson, “to take all necessary steps, including the use of armed forces” to defend South Vietnam. Without a formal declaration of war, the US had committed itself to military conflict in Vietnam.